

The Intersection of Puerto Rican Leftist and Feminist Labor Movements in the Early 1900s

Puerto Rico has a long history of leftist movements that shaped ideologies about women and the working class. The first recorded strike in Puerto Rico occurred in San Juan, the capital of Spain's colonial government.¹ When Spain underwent the "Glorious Revolution" and abolished Puerto Rican slavery in 1873, a new working class emerged. The economic changes pushed farmers to urban centers, so artisans and salaried plantation workers became the backbone of the new urban economy.² By the early 20th century, when Spain had lost control to the US, mutual aid initiatives and other socialist ideas proliferated, and eventually, a new class identity became prominent.³ Socialist movements became more popular among women, who were disillusioned with the patriarchal government.⁴ Parallel to this development, anarchism (ideas about the abolition of government) became popular in cities such as Caguas and Bayamón.⁵ Thus, a socialist feminist movement was born, with activists like Luisa Capetillo — famous for defying gender norms by wearing men's clothing — at its center. Capetillo is most known for her work *Mi Opinión*, which examines the gendered aspects of labor exploitation.⁶ Shortly after, key leftists began advocating for women's labor organization and suffrage. For example, the president of the Federation of Free Workers, Santonio Iglesias, commented on the issue and Bolívar Pagán, vice president of the Socialist Party, wrote a report detailing the importance of women's suffrage.⁷ Ultimately though, labor organization was the movement's

¹ Jorell Meléndez Badillo, "Voces Libertarias: Los orígenes del anarquismo en Puerto Rico" (in Spanish) (3rd ed.), Editorial Akelarre/Centro de Estudios e Investigación del Sureste de Puerto Rico: 96, Accessed 6/4/2023.

² Ibid, pg. 87.

³ Ibid.

⁴ Kirwin R Schaffer, (2013), *Black Flag Boricuas: Anarchism, Antiauthoritarianism, and the Left in Puerto Rico, 1897-1921*, University of Illinois Press: 1, Accessed 6/4/2023.

⁵ Meléndez Badillo, pg. 154.

⁶ Luisa Capetillo, "Mi Opinión," 1911, Google Scholar, Accessed 5/16/2023, <https://cdn.pruebat.org/recursos/recursos/libros/pdf/Mi-opinion.pdf>.

⁷ Santiago Iglesias, 1914, in Blanca Silvestrini-Pacheco, "Women as Workers: The Experience of Puerto Rican Women in the 1930's," Rutgers University, <https://clas.rutgers.edu/docman-lister/projects-and-collaborations/puerto-rico-documents/puerto-rico-archival-collaboration-digitized-books-and-publications/73-silvestrini-women-as-workers-puerto-rican-woman1930s-women-cross>

primary path to success, as Juan S. Marcano, a prominent socialist, explained.⁸ However, labor movements faced challenges from local authorities, as strikers indicated in a 1934 telegram to the governor.⁹ Strikes with women at their center became more common, such as the 1934 needleworkers strike, and they were publicized through worker-aligned newspapers including *La Democracia*.¹⁰ Leftist movements in 20th-century Puerto Rico intersected with feminist movements, advocating for women's labor and electoral rights through their activism; however, feminists faced challenges from a conservative and patriarchal government as well as gender hierarchies within the Socialist Party. Still, Puerto Rican feminists had some success in organizing to effect change at the local level.

Luisa Capetillo, who was a prolific anarchist writer, challenged traditional gender roles through an intersectional, socialist-feminist approach, highlighting the gendered aspects of labor exploitation. In her book, *Mi Opinión*, Capetillo illustrates how the struggles of the working class uniquely impacted women. She deconstructs the household and encourages women to participate in the workforce. However, she highlights the ruthless treatment of working women by society at the time. Capetillo writes, "But what about the poor home, the working-class family... The poor woman who has to go and push the wheelbarrow in the mines, alongside men, going back and forth alone, does she become masculine?"¹¹ Capetillo shows that even when women are working, they are still impacted by systemic misogyny, and ultimately are still subject to disrespect, unfair

[-culturally/file](#); Bolívar Pagán, "El Sufragio Femenino (Estudio Jurídico)," December 29, 1923, Archivo Digital Nacional de Puerto Rico, Accessed May 21, 2023, <https://archivonacional.com/PL/1/1/8804>.

⁸ Juan S. Marcano, 1919, in Blanca Silvestrini-Pacheco, "Women as Workers: The Experience of Puerto Rican Women in the 1930's," Rutgers University, <https://clas.rutgers.edu/docman-lister/projects-and-collaborations/puerto-rico-documents/puerto-rico-archival-collaboration-digitized-books-and-publications/73-silvestrini-women-as-workers-puerto-rican-woman1930s-women-cross-culturally/file>.

⁹ "Women's Union Telegram," in World History Commons, Accessed 6/4/2023, <https://worldhistorycommons.org/womens-union-telegram>.

¹⁰ "Puerto Rican Labor Movement: Newspaper, Needle Worker Strike," in World History Commons, <https://worldhistorycommons.org/puerto-rican-labor-movement-newspaper-needle-worker-strike>.

¹¹ Capetillo, "Mi Opinión." Translated from Spanish.

wages, and other systemic issues despite their work. Thus, Capetillo explains, the capitalist status quo is only harmful to women, who do the same work as men but are not given their privilege. She writes, “The unhappy wife of a factory worker or construction worker who only earns 50 to 60 cents per day, who cannot afford to care for four or six children, who has to dress them and tie their shoes and cannot do so, and in order to support herself, offers to work other jobs and leave her children unattended, is she not harmed?”¹² She notes that even when women are working by supporting their families, they still have to pick up other jobs. Thus, a lower-class woman does significantly more work for fewer returns than the rest of society: she sacrifices time with her children, which amounts to their education, to help put food on the table and support herself. Because of this burden, lower-class families are only further impoverished, and that cycle continues with the only benefit going to the rich. But Capetillo provides a call to action: “Wealthy women! You can redeem your exploited brothers and sisters! Redeem them and the glory will be yours!”¹³ She specifically calls out wealthy women because, while they are impacted by misogyny, they have the resources and social capital to create change. Capetillo’s work and her emphasis on the harm neoliberalism and capitalism cause women combines feminist and socialist ideology to create intersectional change.

Like Capetillo and others, the Puerto Rican Socialist Party advocated for women’s suffrage. However, its advocacy was not successful, as the majority of Puerto Rico and its government were conservative. Bolívar Pagán, the vice president of the Socialist Party in Puerto Rico, published a work demanding universal suffrage. He explains, “Congress was given full power to determine the political condition of Puerto Rico and the civil rights of its inhabitants. The Supreme Court of the United States has so affirmed.”¹⁴ Pagán illustrates that the rights, the

¹² Ibid.

¹³ Ibid.

¹⁴ Pagán, “El Sufragio Femenino (Estudio Jurídico).” Translated from Spanish.

entire humanity, of Puerto Ricans, came under the control of Congress. Yet, as Pagán states, Congress failed to provide the same rights to Puerto Ricans as its non-colonial citizens. Pagán quotes Congress, who said, “The Supreme Court of the Nation has ruled that conferring the right to suffrage only to males is not in conflict with said constitutional amendment because the privilege of suffrage is not an inherent attribute of citizenship.”¹⁵ This was after both the 13th and 19th amendments were passed — the US was consciously denying Puerto Rico rights it had already established were constitutional and necessary. Thus, Bolivar Pagán provides an alternative plan of action: “It is clear and indisputable that the right to suffrage for women in Puerto Rico must be sought in the local constitution, in the Jones Act [which granted Puerto Ricans U.S. citizenship], and in the electoral statute approved by the Legislative Assembly of Puerto Rico.”¹⁶ This is not a call specifically to socialists, but rather, to the general public. He wanted not only his minority party to support women’s suffrage but also the general public — he supported the values of feminism without intrinsically tying them to socialism. Unlike Capetillo, he had not embraced the intersectionality of the movements, but he did recognize it. He wrote, “A democracy without electoral suffrage granted equally to both male and female population is an incomplete democracy,” illustrating how the democracy of Puerto Rico was “a lie and a farce.”¹⁷ Through this rhetoric, Pagán aimed to sow the seeds of anti-imperialism and further his party’s ideology. However, he was not successful. Women’s suffrage was only granted in Puerto Rico in 1935 — Pagán’s work stayed within his political circles. According to the National Park Service, the policy was adopted in response to outside pressure from Congress.¹⁸ Thus, this push from Pagán and the Socialist Party was not impactful on a large scale.

¹⁵ Ibid.

¹⁶ Ibid.

¹⁷ Ibid.

¹⁸ “Puerto Rico and the 19th Amendment,” National Park Service, Accessed 6/4/2023, <https://www.nps.gov/articles/puerto-rico-women-s-history.htm#:~:text=In%201929%2C%20in%20response%20to,granted%20access%20to%20the%20ballot>.

Because of this failure, the Puerto Rican feminist movement's main outlet for change was labor organization. Santonio Iglesias, president of the Federation of Free Workers (a prominent socialist-aligned organization), advocated for more labor organizations for women. He summarized the federation's policy:

The labor leaders should make every possible effort to organize all the workers of both sexes, of all trades and professions, and especially farm workers. We should organize the women in all the areas of industry in which they are employed. We should organize the office employees as well as the women working in the telegraph, the typists, the clerks, the seamstresses as well as the cooks and maids.¹⁹

The quote emphasizes the importance of organizing workers, regardless of gender or occupation, within the labor movement, and the need to unite workers from all sectors to strengthen their collective power and advance their rights and interests. Moreover, it begins to acknowledge the gendered aspects of labor exploitation: it highlights the need to organize women workers in traditionally male-dominated sectors, such as farming or industrial work, as well as in traditionally female-dominated sectors, such as office work or domestic service. Iglesias's intersectional approach had the goal of reaching as many workers as possible and emphasizes the socialist ideology of collective power. However, that puts it in conflict with strictly feminist movements. Iglesias is advocating for women's labor organization, but advocacy for "both sexes" fails to fully address what Capetillo and other socialist feminists pointed out: women were systematically abused by an economic system designed to hinder their mobility. Juan S. Marcano, a shoemaker and socialist, shared the sentiment, saying "The woman worker is our fellow companion in misery and deprivation — it is impossible that she continues to be shamefully exploited... The Socialist Party will end this situation."²⁰ By using the word "our", he makes the upper and middle classes a part of both the problem and the solution: Marcano

¹⁹ Iglesias in Silvestrini-Pacheco, "Women as Workers: The Experience of Puerto Rican Women in the 1930's."

²⁰ Marcano in Silvestrini-Pacheco, "Women as Workers: The Experience of Puerto Rican Women in the 1930's."

implores support for the party to stop labor exploitation, again illustrating the way he uses women's issues to further his party. Unlike Capetillo, he fails to recognize the strain of marriage and other institutions combined with these working hours. While he did advocate for labor organization, it is once again alongside men, rather than a specific approach that prioritizes women.

However, a conservative status quo and the Great Depression prevented the Socialist Party from finding success in its organization. The issues socialists like Marcano pointed out — unemployment, low wages, and bad conditions — persisted and even worsened in the 1920s and 30s due to economic troubles brought on by the Depression.²¹ A string of key figures in the Federation of Free Workers and Socialist Party made alliances with conservative and bourgeois groups.²² Thus, their representation became false and ultimately prioritized large corporations, especially those that were most criticized (tobacco industry, needle workers industry, etc.).²³ Workers, especially women, found themselves without meaningful representation.²⁴ These issues were only compounded by the lack of mainstream Socialist movements designed specifically for women. While Luisa Capetillo was important and did work through the Federation of Free Workers, she was one of the only figures who specifically pointed out the intersectionality of the issue.²⁵ However, her anarchist beliefs remained unpopular among most people until the 1990s.²⁶ Furthermore, the government and police actively tried to suppress labor movements. A telegram from the strike committee of women workers to the governor of Puerto Rico reads “Women

²¹ Blanca Silvestrini-Pacheco, “Women as Workers: The Experience of the Puerto Rican Woman in the 1930's,” Rutgers University, <https://clas.rutgers.edu/docman-lister/projects-and-collaborations/puerto-rico-documents/puerto-rico-archival-collaboration-digitized-books-and-publications/73-silvestrini-women-as-workers-puerto-rican-woman1930s-women-cross-culturally/file>.

²² Ibid.

²³ Ibid.

²⁴ Ibid.

²⁵ Ibid.

²⁶ Schaffer, *Black Flag Boricuas: Anarchism, Antiauthoritarianism, and the Left in Puerto Rico, 1897-1921*, pg. 14.

workers of the strike against the tobacco industry seek protection. The Chief of Police denied it to us. Your Honor, we ask you to guarantee it.”²⁷ The government and police were not on the side of the workers. They actively suppressed organization and ultimately ignored the unequal power dynamics experienced by women in the workforce.

Thus, leftist women broke away from the corrupt Socialist Party and Federation of Free Workers, instead focusing on grassroots, community efforts. They found success through local labor organization, and specifically through the unionization of female laborers. Strikes became the primary mode for creating change. An article published in *La Democracia* titled “The Women Needle Workers of Ponce Agree to Go On Strike” illustrates the significance of female-dominated workplaces striking: “They reject the salary minimum of \$1.50 and fixed maximum of \$3.50... The President of the Local Needle-workers Union, Ms. Clara Marta Concepción, in a meeting that took place last Thursday in the City Hall of Ponce... announced that the union along with others from the island had agreed to strike beginning on this coming Monday.”²⁸ Unlike in the Socialist Party, this was a movement led directly by women (Clara Marta Concepción), for women, similarly to the ideals of Luisa Capetillo. Its focus was women workers — they were not an add-on like in the work of Marcano. The strike was publicized to a wide audience through the newspaper and was able to create concrete change without being hindered by the party.²⁹ The detail that Concepción worked with the town hall illustrates the need for local organization rather than broader ideals: through this local push, Concepción was able to create tangible change rather than cling to a party that failed to employ women in its higher ranks and ultimately betrayed its own ideologies. This was only one of many strikes that occurred in

²⁷ “Women's Union Telegram,” in World History Commons, Accessed 6/4/2023, <https://worldhistorycommons.org/womens-union-telegram>.

²⁸ “Puerto Rican Labor Movement: Newspaper, Needle Worker Strike,” in World History Commons, <https://worldhistorycommons.org/puerto-rican-labor-movement-newspaper-needle-worker-strike>.

²⁹ Ibid.

the 1930s — both the needlework and tobacco industries experienced massive work stoppages led by and including mostly women, raising the awareness of female workers and ultimately leading to more job opportunities, higher wages, less dangerous conditions, and the foundation for modern feminist labor movements.³⁰

The early 1900s in Puerto Rico witnessed the emergence of socialist feminism as a force for social change. Through their tireless activism and writings, Luisa Capetillo and others challenged traditional gender norms, fought for workers' rights, and advocated for women's liberation. She believed in the intersectionality of gender, class, and labor struggles, recognizing that the oppression faced by women was deeply intertwined with capitalist exploitation. The legacy of this socialist-feminist movement inspires contemporary pushes for gender equality and social justice. Socialist activists' courage, resilience, and unwavering commitment to justice and equity serve as a reminder that collective action and solidarity are essential for challenging oppressive structures. Today, women are still participating in grassroots movements to create change, similarly to the activists of early-20th-century Puerto Rico. Thus, a feminist movement that acknowledges the unique way capitalism harms women is once again on the rise, and the work of Luisa Capetillo inspires it. The exploitation of the working class and impoverished perpetuates a cycle of injustice, one that can only be broken through a movement that understands its chains.

³⁰ Silvestrini-Pacheco, "Women as Workers: The Experience of Puerto Rican Women in the 1930's."

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